



Neither Here Nor There



6

The unassumingly-named *MotoGP* comes across as a game that's trying to be a good motorcycle-racing simulator without compromising on the fun of flat-out arcade racing. To its credit, it pulls it off fairly nicely—you don't need much in the cranial department to fire it up and get started for the first time.

There isn't really much more to *MotoGP*—you can either race single races in the Arcade mode, or race all the world's official MotoGP tracks one by one till you drop dead from boredom. Every so often, you'll unlock a reward—like a hidden rider or a cool *MotoGP* movie. Yawn.

For the most part, the game is pretty responsive to the controls, but steering around corners is a

tricky thing to execute properly—even at the maximum, the bikes don't seem to be turning as much as we'd like. We even tried tuning the bike for better cornering, but it doesn't seem to help the situation much. Racing down straight portions is fun, but not fun enough. Simulation geeks are also going to wonder at the fact that no matter how stupidly you execute a wheelie, you seem to come out of it without crashing. Weirder still, you absolutely can't turn to go backwards!

Honestly, they should have stuck to pure simulation like in all the official licensed games—this one is a confusing mish-mash of both styles.

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Developer: Namco, **Publisher:** Sony
Platform: PSP, **Distributor:** Milestone Interactive
Web site: www.milestoneinteractive.com

Insane, Unbridled Fun

Ridge Racer 2 (RR2) has to be one of the most bizarre games we've reviewed here, not because of its concept—it's as simple as it gets—but because it mixes some terrifying flaws with a racing experience that's incredible fun. Good news first: racing in RR2 follows a simple mechanic—go as fast as you can, drift (skid in one direction while you face another) like a maniac to get rewarded with nitrous boosts which make you go even faster so you can drift in crazier fashions. It's a vicious circle, this.

The drifting—undoubtedly the highlight of the game—is tremendous fun, and never seems to get old. The tracks are gorgeous, and are a mix of high-speed and twisty, keeping the interest alive. Opponents are easy to beat till

you get to fourth place—climbing beyond will require you to tune your skills a bit more; challenging enough for us!

On the flip side, the car models themselves aren't that great to look at, and the collision physics are awful at best. The in-game announcer is also as annoying as a blister—like I *really* need to be told that I'm in a heated battle for the lead. If you're into plain-jane racing, this game is going to bore you—it isn't much if you strip it of the drift and nitro.

If you've played the first part, though, you're not going to find *anything* different—it's almost an expansion. Overall, RR2 stands tall on its own, but buy it only if you haven't played RR1.

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8